Gandhi could not have anticipated the developments in international migration and education in the second half of the 20th century. The steady trickle of circulating Indian students gave way to more permanent migration as both Britain and the USA loosened immigration restrictions placed on Indians. More significantly, doctors, nurses, engineers and scientists trained at leading higher education institutions in India, especially the newly set up Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs), and began to migrate to the USA for further studies or work. In the 1960s and 70s, the cumulative stock of these emigrants stood at less than a 1,00,000 people. Four decades later, the annual flow figure had risen well over this number. This phenomenon of high-skilled emigration was dubbed the ‘brain drain’ and received close attention in the public discourse.[30] Three centuries after a potential ‘brain drain’ was detected from Persia to India during the Mughal era, as noted in the first chapter, it would be India’s turn to supply brains to other parts of the world.

There were two aspects of the brain drain, linked with patriotism and public finances. The move abroad was seen by the elite, who didn’t move as an abdication of responsibility, as a step towards undertaking the ‘big reforms’ that India required and young Gandhi had talked about. For those who did move, the prospect of working in the best laboratories of the world and living in large homes, or enjoying a vastly improved standard of living overturned any patriotic sentiment that they may have harboured. The classic 2004 Indian movie, *Swades*, about an Indian project manager at NASA returning to produce electricity in villages, reflected the possibilities and the outliers, but not the general norm. What the Indian elite in America and Britain often missed was not the lack of involvement in India’s politics and development, but the absence of domestic help that they were routinely used to employing in India. ‘In America, we have to do everything on our own,’ is a common phrase heard even today in conversations of transnational families.

‘Brain drain’ was a major rallying cry in the 1970s and 80s because Indian students who went abroad did so after receiving subsidized education. It appeared as if India and many other countries were investing